

Breaks and fills

Breaks and fills are used in dance music and jazz as a way of creating contrast with the established musical flow. They stop the forward momentum of the piece, in order to focus the listener on rhythm, a solo, or even silence.

SEE ALSO

◀ 146–147 Bass

Rock bands

190–191 ▶

Breaks

In a tune, brief departures from the melodic flow are called breaks. Sometimes they can be two or three measures of silence, or they may feature one solo instrument. Breaks can place the listener's focus on the dancing, rather than the music, or they can highlight a quick improvised and flashy solo.

▽ "Tiger Rag"

In this example of a traditional Dixieland tune, the break occurs in the last line, with suggested clarinet or tenor sax notes.

Melody shown here with note stems in the upward direction.

Walking bass line

Clar. solo

Tenor solo

Slurred material is the suggested solo.

Accompaniment should crescendo up until the break to dramatically highlight the solo.

▽ Dance music

Breaks are the places where the melody and harmony wind down for a minute, usually to give the percussionist a place to shine.

4/4

Synth pad	o ~~~~~	o ~~~~~	—	—	o ~~~~~
Bass line	— — —	— — —	—	—	— — —
Vocals	dee dee	dee dee	—	—	dee dee
Percussion	x x x x	x x x x	x x x x	x x x x	x x x x

Break